Volcano for the Agentic AI Era:

Unified Scheduling Across Training, Inference, and Agents

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Speakers

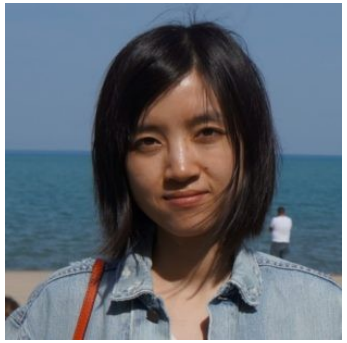


Ricardo Aravena

Cloud Native & AI Infrastructure

Open-source infrastructure
Kubernetes and AI/ML platforms

serverbooter.com



Rainie Li

Pinterest

Data processing infrastructure
Apache YuniKorn PMC member

Apache YuniKorn · rainieli

01

Unified scheduling

01 Unified scheduling

02 Multi-level gang & network topology

03 Ecosystem

04 Benchmark framework & progress

Different paths. Shared infrastructure.

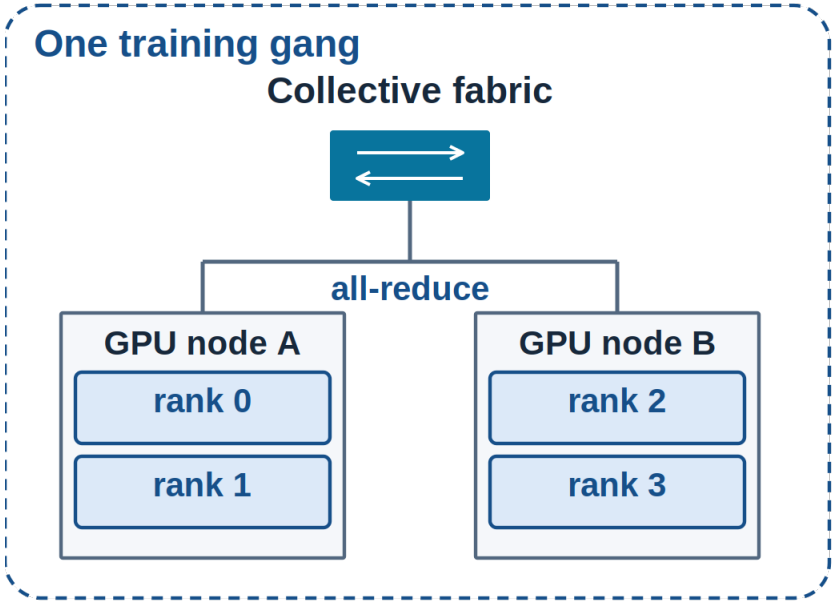
How do schedulers coordinate node access?

Different Workloads, Shared Infrastructure

Training, inference, and agent applications put different demands on the same cluster.

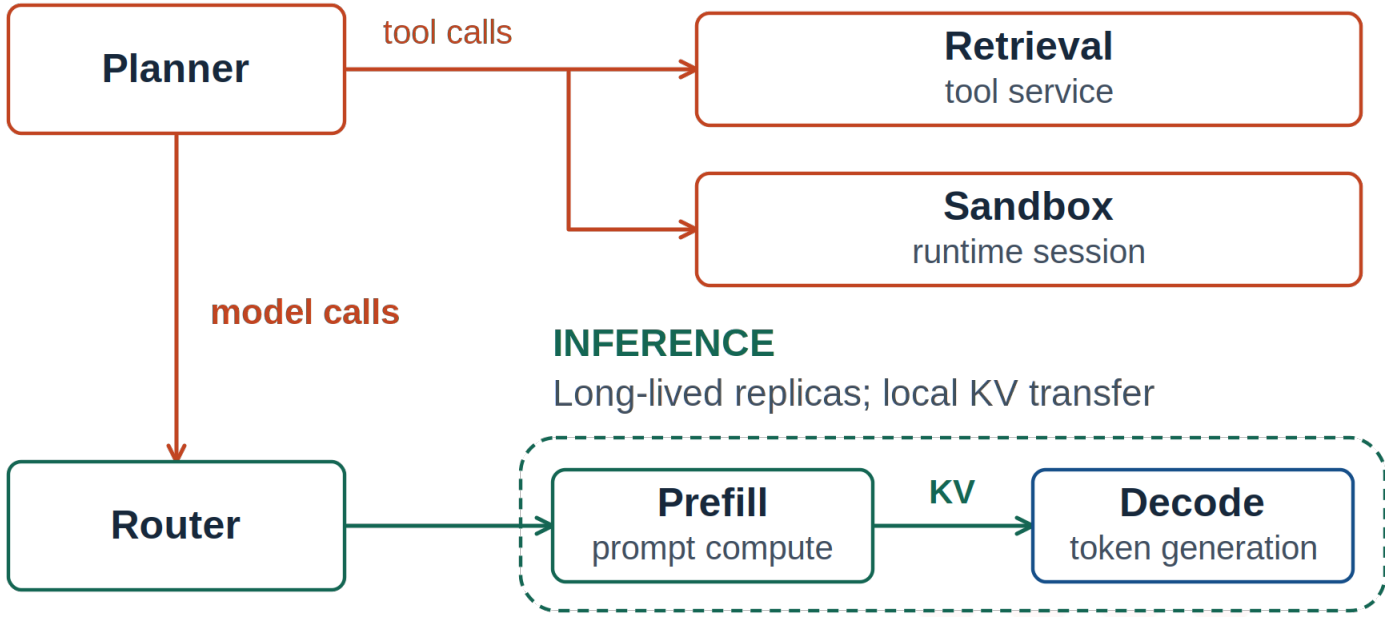
TRAINING & RL

Complete compute groups; collective communication



AGENT APPLICATION

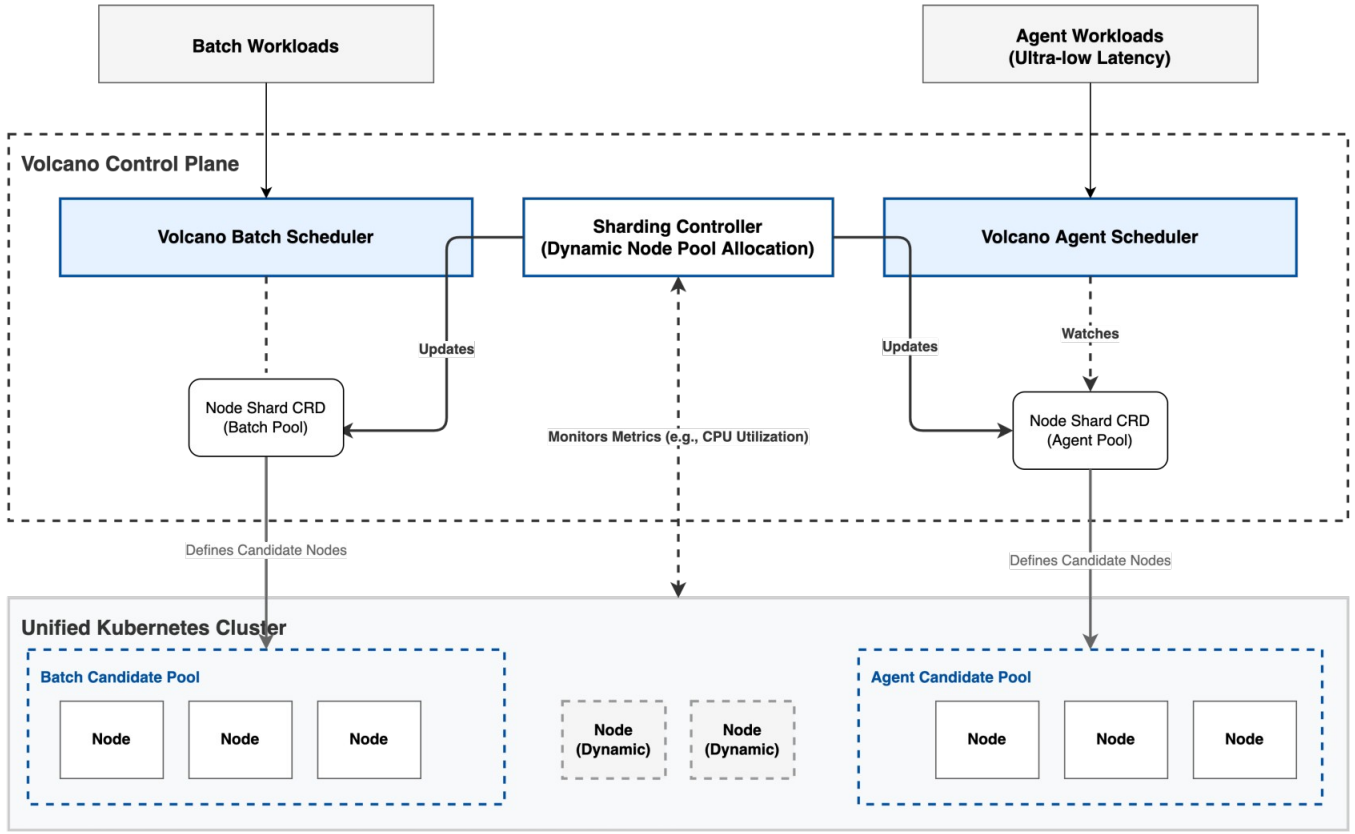
Variable fan-out; latency-sensitive runtime calls



Shared cluster capacity: training needs complete groups; inference needs locality; agents add variable demand.

A Coordinated Scheduling Framework

Specialized scheduling paths coordinate through NodeShard.



01 Workload paths

Batch-oriented scheduling and a Pod-oriented fast path.

02 Local coordination

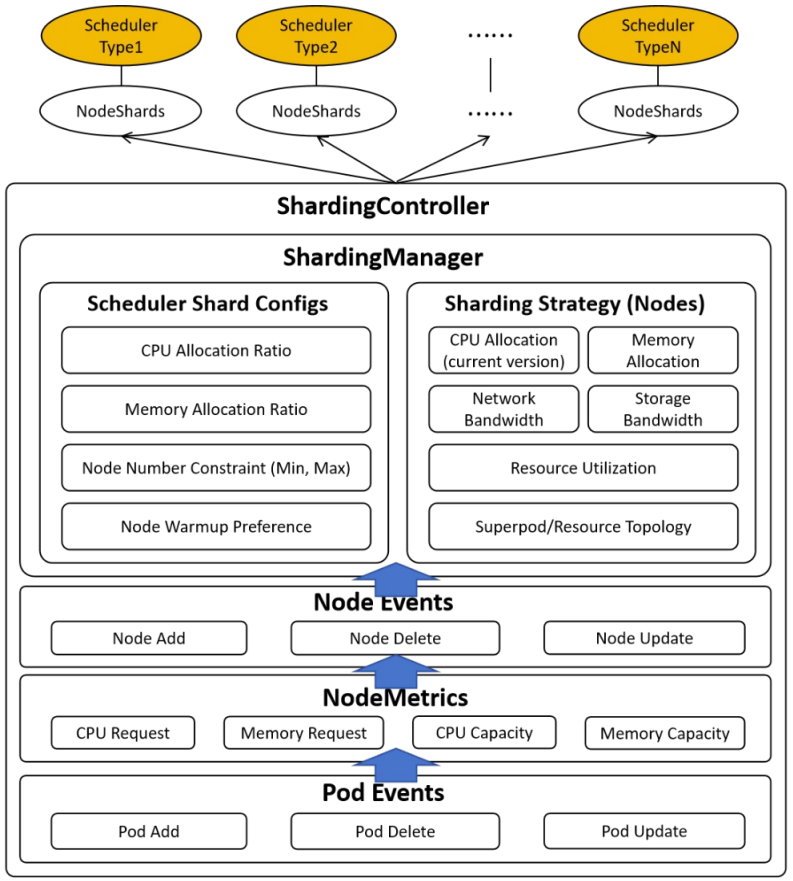
Parallel workers use Binder conflict checks.

03 Shared node access

NodeShard coordinates candidate-node pools.

NodeShard: Desired Nodes and Current Use

Changing a shard coordinates future placement; it does not migrate running Pods.



NodeShard · spec / status excerpt

```
spec:
  nodesDesired:
  - node1
  - node2
status:
  nodesInUse:
  - node0
  - node1
  nodesToRemove:
  - node0
  nodesToAdd:
  - node2
```

Desired membership ≠ immediate use

Coordinators reconcile node access.

02

Multi-level gang & network topology

From available nodes to runnable workloads.

What must run together, and where should it fit?

01 Unified scheduling

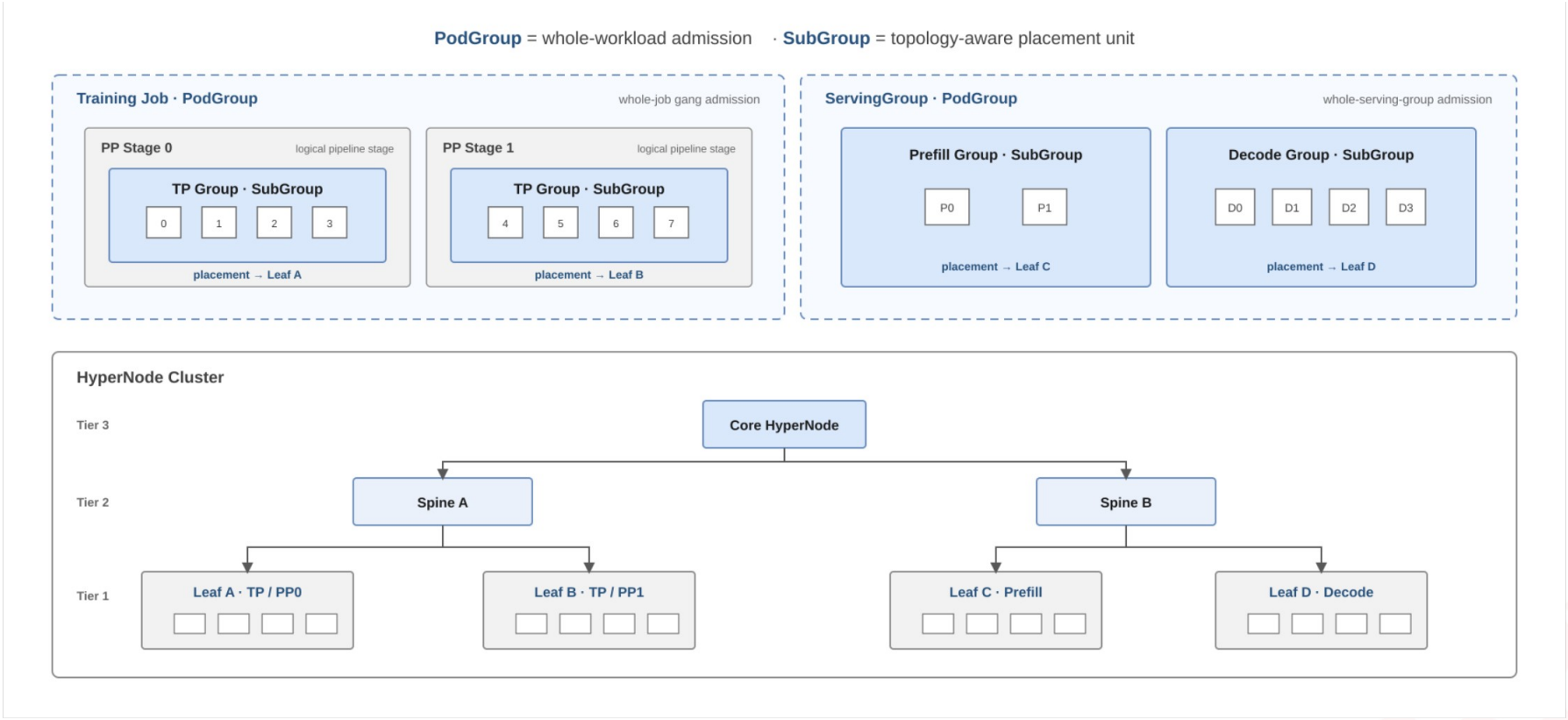
02 Multi-level gang & network topology

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PodGroup and SubGroup: Preserve Workload Structure

Gang requirements apply to the workload and to its complete subgroups.

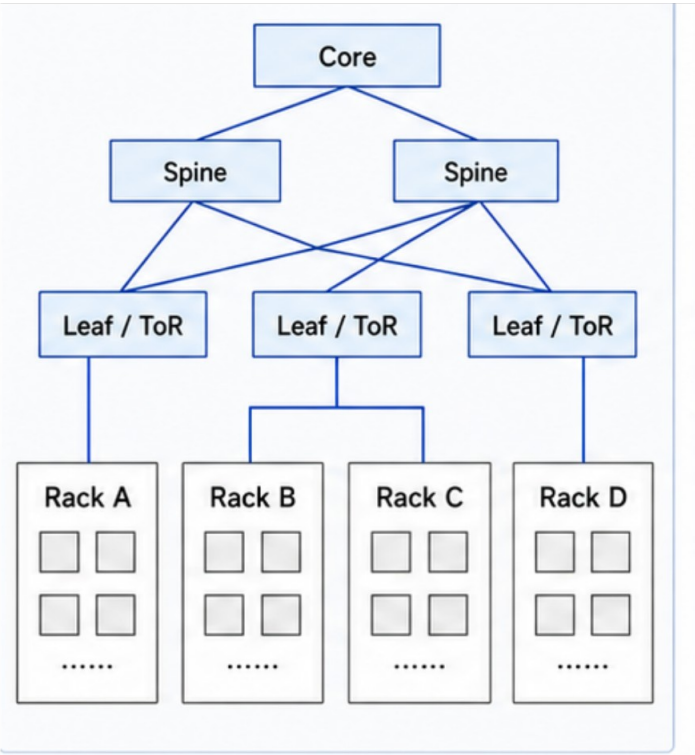


A SubGroup policy selects Pods; replica identity can split them into multiple SubGroups.

HyperNode: From Physical Fabric to Scheduling Domains

A parent HyperNode groups child HyperNodes; a leaf groups Kubernetes Nodes.

PHYSICAL FABRIC



Parent · HyperNode.spec

```
tier: 2
tierName: spine
members:
- type: HyperNode
  selector:
    exactMatch:
      name: rack-a
```

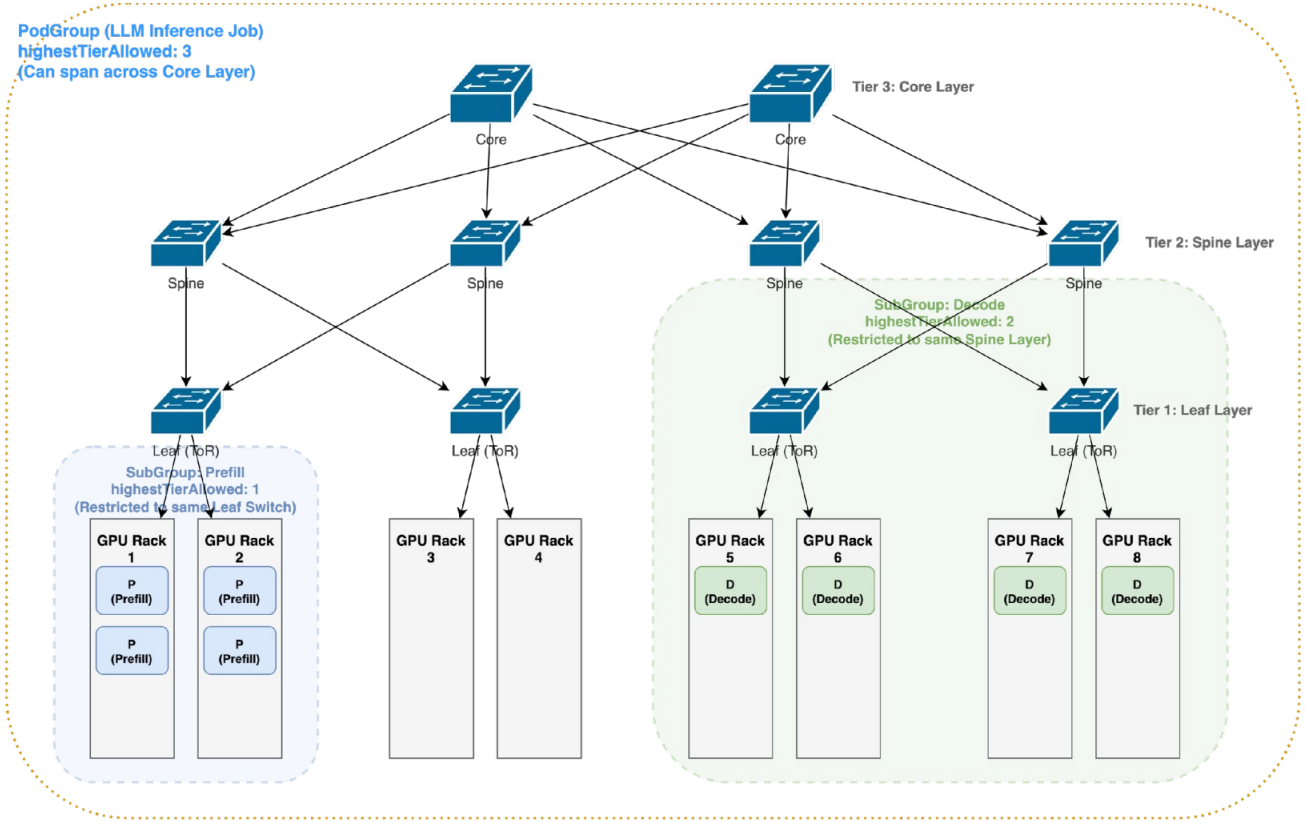
Leaf · HyperNode.spec

```
tier: 1
tierName: leaf
members:
- type: Node
  selector:
    labelMatch:
      matchLabels:
        rack: rack-a
```

The same hierarchy is available through the standalone HyperNode component.

Place Groups at Different Topology Levels

An eight-Pod instance spans a larger domain; Prefill and Decode use different locality constraints.



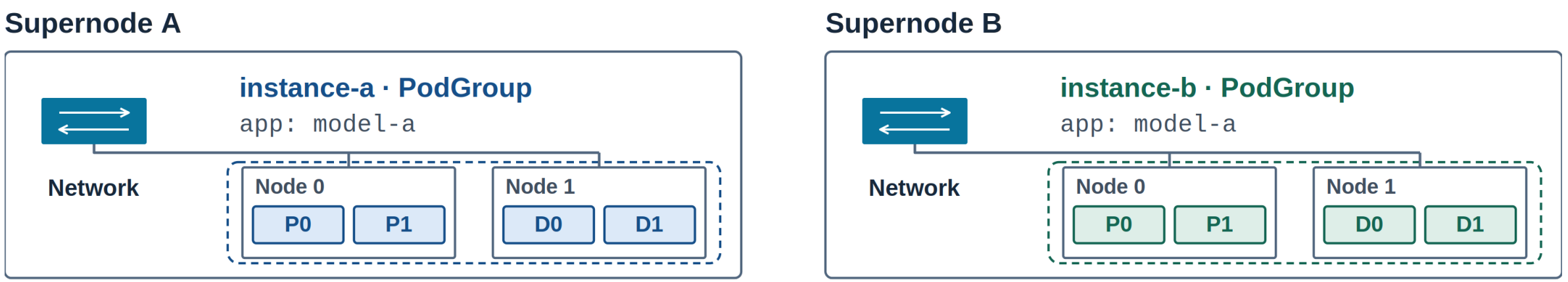
Named tiers: core (3) · spine (2) · leaf (1)

PodGroup.spec · key fields

```
minMember: 8
networkTopology:
  mode: hard
  highestTierName: core
subGroupPolicy:
- name: prefill
  subGroupSize: 4
  networkTopology:
    mode: hard
    highestTierName: leaf
- name: decode
  subGroupSize: 4
  networkTopology:
    mode: hard
    highestTierName: spine
```

Keep Each Instance Together, Place Instances Apart

PodGroup anti-affinity separates service instances across HyperNode domains.



LOCALITY · spec.networkTopology

```
mode: hard
highestTierName: supernode
```

One complete instance inside one domain.

P = Prefill · D = Decode

SEPARATION · spec.topologyAffinity

```
podGroupAntiAffinity:
  required:
  - podGroupSelector:
      matchLabels:
        app: model-a
    topologyTierName: supernode
```

03

Ecosystem

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Workload controllers carry scheduling intent.

How do roles and replicas reach the scheduler?

Controllers Bring Workload Structure to Scheduling

Existing integrations and the next steps in role, replica, and topology support.

INTEGRATIONS & CURRENT GAPS

Kthena

ModelServing → role replicas

Gang and topology available.

KubeRay

Multi-host replica → SubGroup

Gang merged; topology in progress.

Grove

PodClique / scaling group → SubGroup

Backend merged; topology mapping remains.

NEXT COMMUNITY WORK

RBG — IN PROGRESS

RoleInstance → SubGroup foundation.

Continue the integration with the community.

Kubeflow — PLANNED

Build on the existing Volcano plugin.

Extend finer grouping and topology support.

LWS — PLANNED · MULTI-GROUP

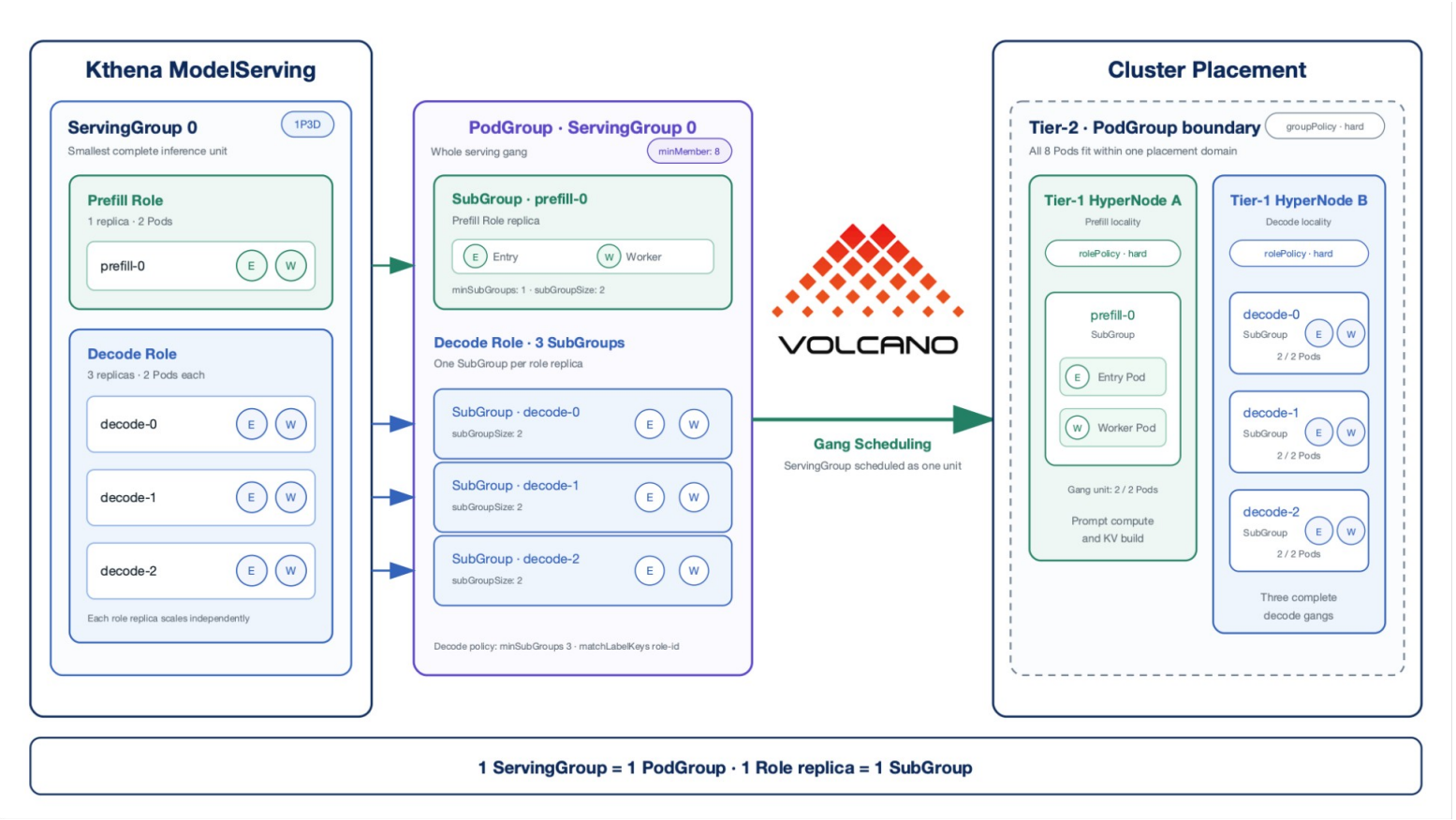
Build on existing gang scheduling.

Connect multi-role groups to scheduling intent.

The next integration step: preserve roles, replica identity, and locality across controller boundaries.

Kthena: From Serving Roles to Scheduling Groups

One ServingGroup maps to one PodGroup; each role replica forms a SubGroup.



ModelServing.spec · excerpt

```
schedulerName: volcano
replicas: 1
template:
  gangPolicy:
    minRoleReplicas:
      prefill: 1
      decode: 3
  roles:
  - name: prefill
    replicas: 1
    workerReplicas: 1
  - name: decode
    replicas: 3
    workerReplicas: 1
```

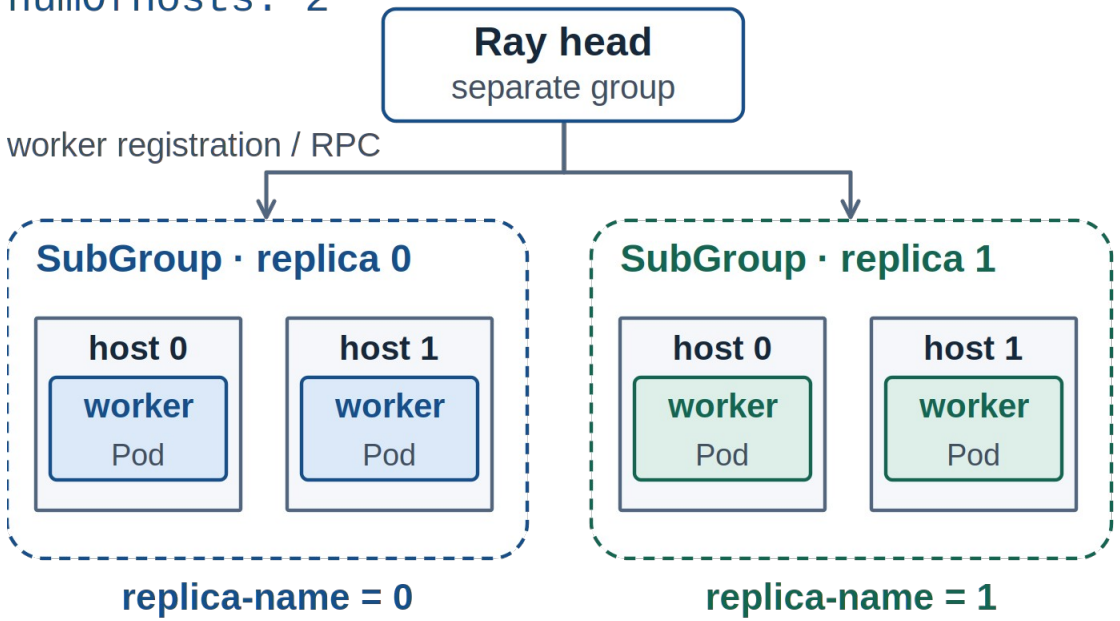
Pod templates omitted.

KubeRay: A Replica Can Span Multiple Pods

The replica label separates complete groups inside one WorkerGroup.

RayCluster · worker group

```
minReplicas: 2
numOfHosts: 2
```



PodGroup.spec · generated grouping

```
subGroupPolicy:
- name: worker
  labelSelector:
    matchLabels:
      ray.io/group: worker
  matchLabelKeys:
  - ray.io/worker-group-replica-name
  minSubGroups: 2
  subGroupSize: 2
```

One replica label → one complete SubGroup

Two replicas × two hosts = four worker Pods

Grouping view, not a topology guarantee. Gang support is merged; replica topology is still in progress.

Next: Relationships Between SubGroups

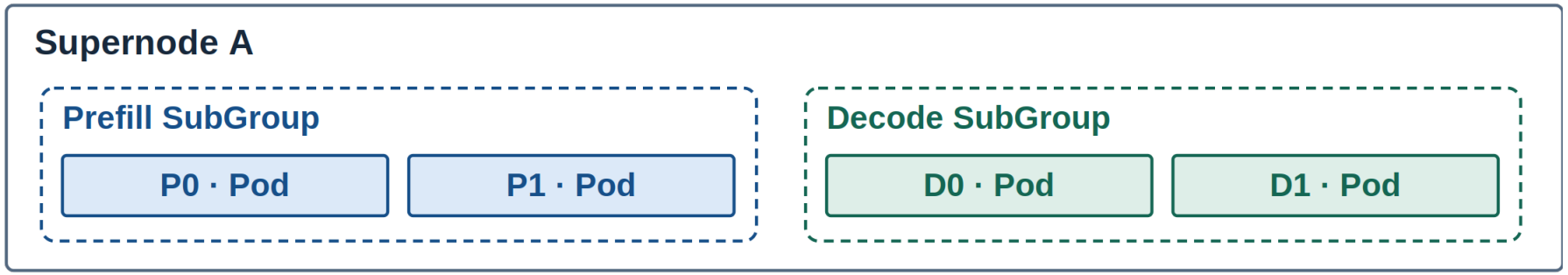
Extend the placement model as controllers expose richer workload structure.

PROPOSED · relationships between SubGroups inside one PodGroup

Affinity

Prefill + Decode

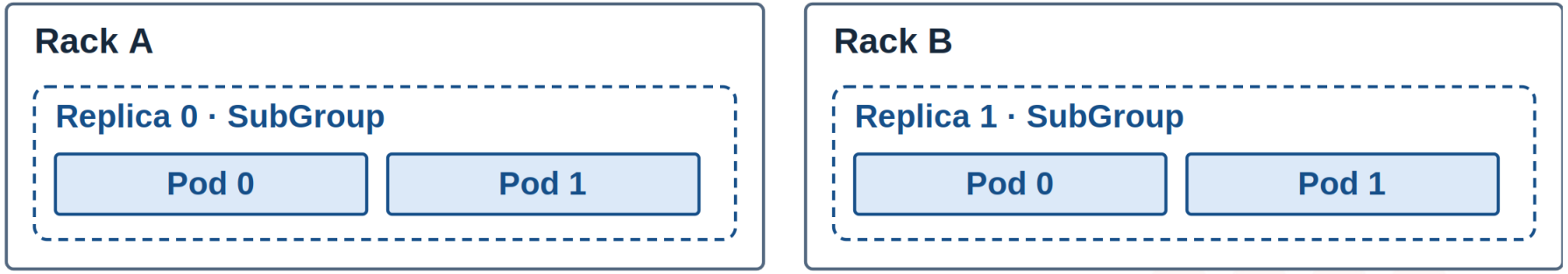
Keep cooperating groups local.



Anti-affinity

Independent replicas

Use different topology domains.



Solid outline: topology domain. Dashed outline: SubGroup. Relationship APIs remain under discussion.

04

Benchmark framework & progress

Measure behavior across workload shapes.

What can we reproduce, compare, and improve?

01 Unified scheduling

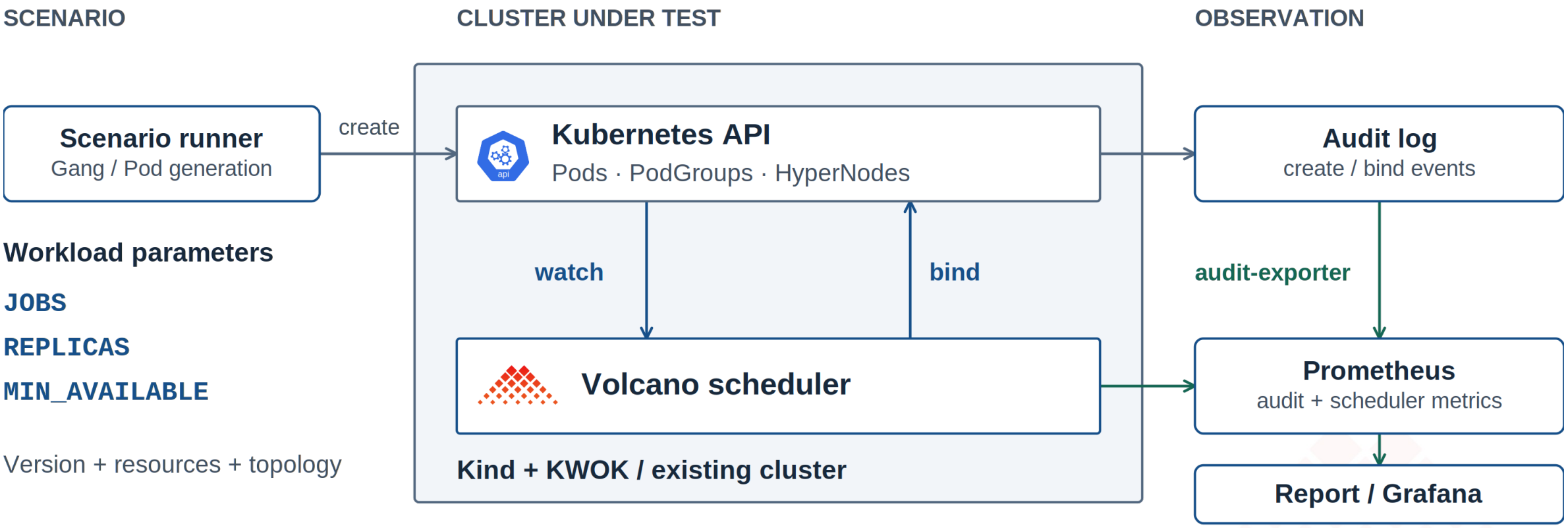
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A Repeatable Scheduling Benchmark Framework

Generate scenarios, observe API events, and retain comparable measurements.



The harness controls the scenario and records observations; KWOK does not execute GPU work.

Benchmark Progress and Ongoing Validation

The harness is available; testing and optimization continue across workload scenarios.

RUN A SCENARIO · benchmark/

```
make setup

make test-gang-env \
  JOBS=10 REPLICAS=100 \
  MIN_AVAILABLE=100
```

COLLECT THE EVIDENCE

`logs/kube-apiserver-audit.log`

`results/report-<timestamp>.json`

ONGOING VALIDATION

01 Vary one dimension

Workload size, grouping, or topology.

02 Keep the comparison fixed

Version, resources, and metric definitions.

03 Repeat and inspect

Retain raw events; investigate bottlenecks.

Available: scenario setup, Gang / Pod workloads, topology, metrics, and report collection.

Benchmark Metrics: Latency and Throughput

Separate scheduling delay, runtime readiness, and successful binding throughput.

Scheduling latency

One Pod · creation to scheduling

created

scheduled

runtime / application

ready

Latency

`scheduledAt − createdAt`

Report P50 / P90 / P99

Scheduling throughput

Successful pods/binding events

ResponseComplete · HTTP 2xx

First successful bind

$$N / \Delta t$$

N = successful bindings

Δt = last bind − first bind

Last successful bind

Definitions only; no result values shown. Compare runs with the same version, workload, and resources.

What We Will Work On Next

Next steps in group placement, controller integration, and benchmarking.

WORKSTREAM	NEXT STEP	WHAT TO VALIDATE
Group placement	**SubGroup affinity / anti-affinity** Extend the existing gang and topology model.	Cooperating groups stay local; replicas use separate domains.
Community integration	**RBG · Kubeflow · LWS multi-group** Carry roles and replica identity into scheduling.	Controllers preserve complete groups and map placement constraints.
Benchmark validation	**Repeat runs across workload shapes** Vary scale, grouping, and topology.	Retain latency distributions, binding throughput, and raw events.

Bring a controller mapping, a placement requirement, or a reproducible workload to the community.

Questions & Discussion

Workload shapes, integration feedback, and reproducible observations are welcome.

What must run together?

What should stay apart?

Bring a workload, a topology constraint, or a reproducible test.

github.com/volcano-sh/volcano

Roadmap and feedback · issue #6166